

idea of "breath," the Avestan starts from the verb "think." A smaller point I may just name before I pass from this comparison. In *Ys* 33^b we read of "the Dominion of Good Thought" (*χῥαθρᾶν νανήδυσῃ mananhō*). So we may have one of the Hexad depending on another, instead of on Mazdah. It is perhaps not too fanciful to compare the occasional appearance of τὸ πνεῦμα Ἰησοῦ or Χριστοῦ in the New Testament as a designation of the Third Person of the Trinity.

I must pass on from these necessarily abtruse points of theology, in which it is easy for one who is neither philosopher nor expert in the history of dogma to stumble. Whether my comparison hitherto has been just or fanciful, I am on sure ground when I point out the general resemblance of the paths by which the two religions reached the heights of monotheism. To each people when polytheism still reigned there came a great Prophet, the centre of whose message was to bid them fix their thought and faith on One alone. But neither Moses nor Zarathushtra denied the existence of other beings called divine. The Gathas know nothing of gods who could be regarded as inferior to Mazdah but on his side. For Zarathushtra, we should judge, the step was already taken which late in Israel's history made the gods of other peoples real divinities, but of devilish nature. In the Inscriptions, however, Ahura Mazdah is "the greatest of gods (*maθišta bagānām*)," and these "gods (*baga*)" are beneficent. We may assume safely that if Zarathushtra tried to ignore these inferior deities he failed to carry his people with him. The growth of monotheism, after the primary impulse was spent, lay along the same lines in both nations.

The transcendence of the one national deity—Ahura Mazda, “the God of the Aryans,” Yahweh, “the God of Israel”—became more and more marked with time; and ultimately the nation reached a real monotheism by this road. In each case there is a possibility that the Founder reached it ages before. It may be added that the lines of religious declension were much the same. The old polytheism in each case constantly threatened to return. Mithra and Anahita might in theory be only *yazata*, angels subordinated to the only God, just as in medieval Christianity Michael and the Virgin were by theologians kept wholly apart from Deity. But with the populace the distinction was unreal, and polytheism virtually returned, as it did throughout the history of Israel before the Captivity.

The part played by the Prophet may be compared with suggestive results. Zarathushtra stands solitary in the history of Parsism, while Moses has a series of successors, some of whom were at least as great as himself. There lies the most important part of the ultimate difference between the destiny of the religions. In other respects the parallel will hold. Each Founder was credited in later days with a complete legislative system, which in Zarathushtra's case was the work of men wholly alien¹ from his spirit. By way of compensation, the men who mis-

¹ Here I must chronicle the fact that my friend Prof. Jackson sprinkles queries about these two words. His opinion is worth so much more than mine that the reader should be told when I am venturing without his company. My main contention is that the *ritual* of the Vendidad was alien to Zarathushtra, who, as I understand him, had nothing of the ritual or the sacerdotal in his system. But I have no doubt that without their adaptation Zarathushtra's thought would have failed to survive.

represented him—unconsciously enough, we may probably assume—elevated him to a virtually divine rank, and supported the apotheosis with a multitude of singularly feeble miracles. It will be admitted that the memory of Moses was hallowed in ways more congruous with the Prophet's true character and message.

When we come down from the Doctrine of God into the comparatively indifferent sphere of angelology, we are entering a subject where dispute is more feasible. But even here we may put in the forefront some coincidences which none would claim to be anything else. The prominence of Fire in both religions will be one, for it is too obviously old to be conceivably borrowed. "The Fire of Yahweh" and "the Fire of Ahura Mazdah" are parallel phrases, and the associations of each are very similar. Yet it is clear that the sacredness of Fire as an emblem came to Iran and to Israel by totally different roads. The Zoroastrian *Âtar*, with which we compared the Latin *âtrium*, the room where the house-fire burnt, was in its origin neither sacrificial nor elemental, but represented simply the fire of the hearth, which in a country of intensely cold winters had never lost the supreme importance belonging to it in the *Urheimat* in Northern Europe and through the long migrations over the Steppes. The Fire of Yahweh was in its origin, we may suppose, the lightning:¹ the narratives

¹ Or the volcano: I do not pretend to determine a matter which concerns the Old Testament specialist. There is much interesting matter on this subject in Hugo Gressmann's *Eschatologie*. Dr Gressmann would trace a connexion between volcanic theophanies and the *ayah* *xšusta*, comparing especially Enoch 52⁶ 67⁴ ff., where we have mountains of metal that melt. He would also (see p. 37-40)